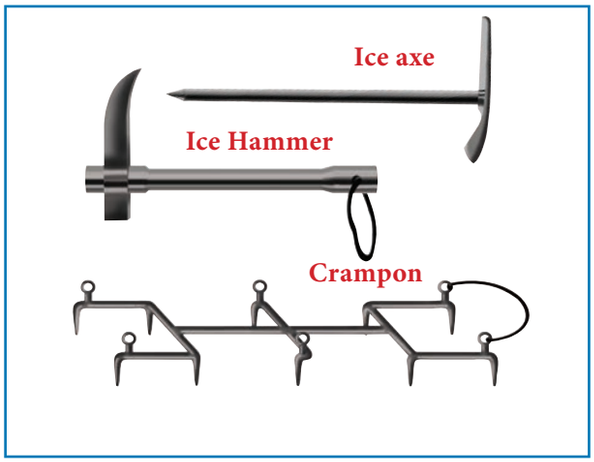
11. We moved one at a time. I would cut a forty foot line of steps, Tenzing belaying me while I worked. Then in turn I would sink my shaft and put a few loops of the **rope** around it, and Tenzing, protected against a breaking step, would move up to me. Then once again as he belayed me I would go on cutting.

12. In a number of places the overhanging ice **cornices** were very large indeed, and in order to escape them I cut a line of steps down to where the snow met the rocks on the west. It was a great thrill to look straight down this enormous rock face and to see, 8000 feet below us, the tiny tents of Camp 4 in the Western **Cwm. Scrambling** on the rocks and cutting handholds on the snow, we were able to shuffle past these difficult portions.

13. On its east side was another great cornice; and running up the full forty feet of the step was a narrow crack between the cornice and the rock. Leaving Tenzing to belay me as best he could, I jammed my way into this crack. Then, kicking backwards, I sank the spikes of my crampons deep into the frozen snow behind me and levered myself off the ground.



14. Taking advantage of every little rock hold, and all the force of knee, shoulder, and arms I could muster, I literally cramponed backwards up the crack, praying that the cornice would remain attached to the rock. My progress although slow was steady. As Tenzing paid out the rope, I inched my way upwards until I could reach over the top of the rock and drag myself out of the crack on to a wide ledge.



15. For a few moments I lay regaining my breath, and for the first time really felt the fierce determination that nothing now could stop us reaching the top. I took a firm stance on the ledge and signalled to Tenzing to come on up. As I heaved hard on the rope, Tenzing **wriggled** his way up the crack, and finally collapsed at the top like a giant fish when it has just been hauled from the sea after a terrible struggle.

16. The ridge continued as before: giant cornices on the right; steep rock sloped on the left. The ridge curved away to the right and we have no idea where the top was. As I cut around the back of one hump, another higher one would swing into view. Time was passing and the ridge seemed never-ending.

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